

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 1029

By Camper

A RESOLUTION to honor and commend Deborah Manning Thomas for her many contributions as a gospel musician.

WHEREAS, it is fitting that the members of this General Assembly should pause to recognize those Tennesseans who enrich the lives of their fellow citizens through musical performance; and

WHEREAS, one such individual is Deborah Manning Thomas, one of Tennessee's most distinguished and beloved gospel vocalists, whose life and career reflect her profound commitment to faith, artistry, and service; and

WHEREAS, a native of Memphis, Ms. Thomas began singing at the age of six, nurtured by the rich musical traditions of the Black church; her roots were firmly planted at Golden Leaf Missionary Baptist Church, where she was guided and inspired by Reverends Cleophus Robinson and Oris L. Mays; and

WHEREAS, Ms. Thomas continued her musical ministry at Olivet Baptist Church, singing with the Olivet Celestial Voices under the leadership of Pastor Kenneth Twigg Whalum, Sr.; and

WHEREAS, while she was a student at Memphis State University, Deborah Thomas was recognized for her extraordinary talent by Dr. Erma L. Clanton, who cast her in the production *An Evening of Soul*, a performance that became a defining moment and led to her mentorship under legendary musician Isaac Hayes; and

WHEREAS, Deborah Thomas went on to perform in Los Angeles, California, in the gospel segment of the historic Wattstax concert in 1972, singing Thomas A. Dorsey's timeless hymn "Precious Lord, Take My Hand"; and

WHEREAS, Ms. Thomas's artistic career spanned not only music but also theater and film; she appeared as the Quinn family maid in *The Firm*, starring Tom Cruise, and as a choir singer in *Hustle and Flow*; and

WHEREAS, on stage, Ms. Thomas brought legendary gospel figures to life, portraying Mahalia Jackson for three seasons at the Hattiloo Theatre and earning acclaim for her portrayal of Sister Rosetta Tharpe in the production of *Marie and Rosetta*; and

WHEREAS, beyond gospel music, Ms. Thomas has performed at venues across the country, including NAACP Freedom Fund Banquets, and opened for National Civil Rights Museum ceremonies; and

WHEREAS, her voice was included on several notable recordings by STAX recording artists, and she continues to inspire people from all walks of life with her incredible gift; her recorded works are available on streaming platforms and include the independently released gospel project *Blest Be the Tie* (1992), the single "Shout Now" released during the COVID-19 pandemic, and her latest single, "My Trust in You" (2025); and

WHEREAS, Deborah Thomas is currently a devoted member of Christ Missionary Baptist Church under the leadership of Dr. Gina M. Stewart; she faithfully serves as a member of the Women of Wisdom ministry, which is committed to encouraging and empowering young women; and

WHEREAS, in addition to teaching Christian music to church workers across the State, Ms. Thomas served two terms as president of the music department within the Tennessee Baptist Missionary and Educational Convention, in which role she made lasting contributions to arts education and ministry; and

WHEREAS, apart from her fruitful career as an artist, Ms. Thomas retired from her position with the Office of the Shelby County Criminal Court Clerk following twenty-five years of astute service; and

WHEREAS, wholly devoted to her family, Deborah Thomas is the proud mother of three adult children and grandmother of four grandsons; and

WHEREAS, through her voice, service, and unwavering faith, Ms. Thomas has left an indelible mark on the cultural and spiritual landscape of Tennessee and the global music industry; and

WHEREAS, her continued contributions to gospel music are unparalleled, and her steadfast commitment to the genre, as well as her undeniable talent, will continue to inspire generations with messages of faith, resilience, and praise; and

WHEREAS, Deborah Thomas epitomizes the spirit and commitment to family and community that are characteristic of a true Tennessean; and

WHEREAS, it is most fitting that we recognize one of Tennessee's most outstanding citizens at this time; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we hereby honor and commend Deborah Manning Thomas for her many contributions as a gospel musician and extend to her our best wishes for much continued success.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.